

Catechumen Reflection Questions

God bless you on your faithful journey to Orthodoxy. You have diligently studied the history, theology, and tenets of the faith, and have expressed your genuine desire to be a part of the Orthodox Christian Church. The following questions are an opportunity for you to reflect upon some of the core and more personal aspects of the faith, and share where you are in your current relationship with Orthodox Christianity.

The point in answering these questions is NOT to provide the “right answer” but to provide YOUR thoughts and reflections. This is NOT an exam or an academic evaluation or test by any means. These questions, along with your responses, are fundamentally to provide and facilitate further discussion and exploration of your faith and feelings about the Church, especially as we come nearer to your Baptism/Chrismation into the Orthodox Church. Do not feel the need to answer in great length, and do not feel rushed to answer and respond quickly either. Take your time and offer your responses in a prayerful, truthful, and deliberate manner.

To God be the glory!

-Fr. Chris Retelas

1. Please share briefly your faith background and upbringing, your discovery and journey to Orthodoxy, and to where you are on that journey today.

A:

I was nominally raised Protestant, but our church attendance was sporadic, and I never developed a strong connection to the faith. Over time, my family largely stopped attending, though both of my parents returned to their faith before they passed. After my mother's passing, I sought a deeper spiritual connection but found Protestant services lacking in tradition and meaning. Being married to a Catholic, I respected the Church but never felt truly engaged. A tragic event involving a friend's death reinforced my desire for faith grounded in truth and history. Then, last August, I discovered Orthodoxy through YouTube—specifically, stories of former punk musicians who found faith in monastic life. That led me to attend my first service at St. John's, where I immediately felt I had found what I had been missing. I've been attending ever since.

2. Who is Jesus Christ? And who is He to you?

A:

Since connecting with the Orthodox faith, he's everything.

The friend who is always there.

The ultimate teacher and Father Figure

The figure who's teachings have voided any need of a psychological counselor. Jesus Christ is the guiding light who has patiently led me through different seasons of my faith journey, even when I didn't fully realize it. He is the Truth I have sought, the one who answered my desperate prayers, and the reason I kept searching for something deeper than what I had encountered before. In Orthodoxy, I've found a faith that connects me not only to Him but to the fullness of His Church—rooted in history, tradition, and genuine worship.

3. *What position do you feel the Virgin Mary holds in the faith of the Orthodox Christian?*

A:

Mary is the Mother of the Church and a model of pure devotion and sacrifice to God. As a former Protestant, connecting with her is new to me, but I admire her unwavering faith and compassion, embracing all of us with a deep motherly love,

4. *Who are the Saints? What is the relationship an Orthodox Christian has with the Saints?*

A: This is where I need the most guidance. I have read and learned a bit about St. Paisios, St. Nectarios and Seraphim Rose, but connect with them at this stage more like great literary figures. Again, being raised as a protestant and never embracing or understanding Catholic saints, this is all new to me. I see them as great role models and great resources to learn from, but I need help in understanding how to connect with them on a spiritual level.

5. *What role do icons hold in the life, faith, and worship of the Orthodox Church?*

A:

I know that the icons are windows into the divine world, connecting us to the reality of Christ, the Theotokos, and the saints. They are not simply beautiful art, but sacred tools for worship, teaching, and prayer to help to deepen our faith and remind us of God's presence. Through veneration, we honor those depicted, not the images themselves, reaffirming the Incarnation and the sanctification of the material world.

6. *What is the function and importance of fasting for the Orthodox Christian?*

A:

Fasting is a spiritual discipline that cultivates self-control and detachment from worldly

comforts. It serves to redirect our focus from physical needs to prayer and communion with God. Through fasting, we humble ourselves, seek repentance, and grow in faith.

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7. *How central are the Sacraments to the faith and salvation of an Orthodox Christian?*

A:

They are the means by which we receive God's grace and participate in His divine life. Through Baptism, we enter the Church; in the Eucharist, we unite with Christ; and through Confession, we receive His mercy. Each Sacrament deepens our relationship with God, leading us on the path of salvation.

8. *What does "salvation" mean to you?*

A: Salvation means union with God—being healed, transformed, and drawn into His divine life. It's not just about avoiding punishment but about becoming more like Christ through faith, repentance, and participation in the Church. It is a lifelong journey of growing in love, humility, and holiness, striving to align my will with God's.

Fr. Chris:

Moving forward, I hope that the following questions will be discussed with the class:

1. Planning for Baptism day: what to wear, what to bring, will there be a timeline provided? Will there be any sort of group rehearsal beforehand?
2. How crowded might the Church be on this day? Should we refrain from inviting too many others?